# A Piece of My Heart

## By Shirley Lauro

**MARTHA:** **(Pg 14)** *(Smiling ruefully)* I was an army brat. Martha O'Neil. Dad a career man. Mom a navy nurse. World War II. I was born at Ft. Benning, grew up at Ft. Bragg. I remember one day in junior high, a girlfriend came in crying: her dad was going to Vietnam. They sent her home . . . must've been around 1961. . . so I knew early on about Vietnam. Americans being killed there. Back of my mind was: ***I*** want to go there. Be a Navy nurse, serve my country and protect our men.

**LEEANN:** **(Pg 17)** I was anti-war! So [were] my friends! We were hippies – Woodstock, bell bottom jeans, headbands, the long hair . . . Then I remember Kennedy going, "What can you do for your country?" Well, I was twenty-one when an Army recruiter comes to my nursing school dressed in her uniform – showing us this wonderful film about the glamour of being an Army nurse and these gorgeous hospitals all over the world with all this modern equipment. And I was very impressed!

## INTRODUCTION

*Elizabeth Kenny once said, "When you're a nurse you know that every day you will touch someone's life or someone's life will touch yours." In Vietnam countless lives were touched by the devoted nurses who cared around the clock for our fallen troops. In this selection, we meet a group of young women: Martha, Leann, Sissy, Whitney and MaryJo -- who dreamed of becoming military nurses for a variety of reasons, but none are prepared for the true atrocities of war.*

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**INSTRUCTOR 1:** **(Pg 22-23)** Ladies! There are ways to be a young lady worthy of the Red Cross!

**INSTRUCTOR 2:** At all times be feminine!

**INSTRUCTOR 1:** Never swear!

**INSTRUCTOR 2:** Never be provocative with men!

**INSTRUCTOR 1:** Because you are a Red Cross girl!

**INSTRUCTOR 2:** Symbol of Purity.

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**INSTRUCTOR 1:** Goodness, and Light!

**INSTRUCTOR 2:** Sister, Mother, Girl- Next-Door.

**INSTRUCTOR 1:** ***The*** All American Girl to every service man you meet!

**SERGEANT:** **(Pg 26)** ATTENTION!

**OFFICER:** All of you have orders for Southeast Asia.

**SERGEANT:** Dismissed!

**SISSY:** They wouldn't even say Vietnam.

**LEEANN:** I'm going to my head nurse *(shift of scene)* **(Pg 27)** But I'm anti-war. I'll take care of them in Hawaii.

**HEAD NURSE 1:** They're overstaffed there. And you're top of the line. You can make a real contribution in Vietnam.

**WHITNEY:** *(to audience)* **(Pg 28)** And they put us on an airplane in little powder blue, Red Cross uniforms and dixie cup hats and heels and stockings!

**MARTHA:** And off we go

**MARYJO:** *(to audience)* **(Pg 29)** There are just a few women on my plane – two hundred men! And everybody is trying to be sweet

**SISSY:** Singing, drinking, playing checkers –

**LEEANN:** I ask my stewardess for a pillow – she pretends she doesn't hear me – she brings pillows to the men

**MARTHA:** **(Pg 30)** Then suddenly it all just quiets down *(looking out plane windows)*

**MARYJO:** No one talks.

**SISSY:** Nobody says a word.

**WHITNEY:** VIETNAM! Look how beautiful it is . . .

**MARTHA:** How can there be a war way down there? *(Sound of BOOM)*

**STEELE:** **(Pg 31-32)** My God!!! Tracers!

**LEEANN:** Puffs of smoke!

**WHITNEY:** *(stunned)* We're being fired on!

**SISSY:** FIRED ON? I haven't done anything to them!

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**LEEANN:** I'm a nurse!

**SOLDIER:** There are Viet Cong on the landing fields

**LEEANN:** *(lights go out)* Night! Blackout! Can't see the runway! Nothing! Dead silent on the plane!

**SISSY:** But I hear 247 souls breathing . . .

**WHITNEY:** The doors open –

**MARTHA:** Spotlights flashing --

**LEEANN:** Vietnamese – everywhere – screaming – shrieking –

**OFFICER:** **(Pg 34)** Attention! All new nurses report to North area at once!

******scene******

**MARTHA:** *(to audience)* **(Pg 37)** The hospital is a series of Quonset huts – I'm assigned to the night shift.

**HEAD NURSE 2:** *(initial tour of the facility)* **(Pg 38-39)** Here on the wards you will be responsible for 300 to 350 patients. As supervisor you will care for the sickest patients yourself.

**MARTHA**: *(staggered)* 350 patients?

**HEAD NURSE 2:** Night duty is the hardest, of course. People die at night. And wounded people, Captain, get very frightened at night. They moan, they cry out . . .

**MARTHA:** **(Pg 40)** But there are so ***many*** injuries – and the ***kinds*** of injuries – **(Pg 39)** *(to audience)* Respirators! Catheters! Drains! I've never seen anything like this in my life!

**HEAD NURSE 2:** *(interrupting)* **(Pg 40)** Stuff it, Captain! Or you will never be of use! Your work is to patch up the soldier so he can get back to the battle field – **(Pg 39)** Build a psychological wall! **(Pg 40)** Don't think! Stay behind your wall!

******scene******

**VOICE ON INTERCOM:** **(Pg 41-42)** There is a mass casualty coming in. All ***new*** nurses report at once to Emergency. I repeat: Mass casualty is coming in. *(a scramble, then shock as the first GI is brought in – then rapid overlapping chaos)*

**LEEANN:** **(Pg 44)** Holy shit!

**SISSY:** He's got no legs! Thighs down!

**MARTHA:** Gone!

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**LEEANN:** So much blood! The doctors and nurses are doing then thousand things.

**MARTHA:** **(Pg 45-46)** Blood is spurting up!

**SISSY:** BLOOD IS SPURTING UP!

**MARTHA:** *(to audience)* I can't move! I can't talk! I can't do anything! Amputations –

**LEEANN:** Burn cases –

**MARTHA:** Part of me is saying:

**LEEANN:** Jesus Christ! Just look at this!

**SISSY:** The other part says:

**LEEANN:** What's your problem?

**HEAD NURSE 1:** Nurse, start the IV! Nurse!

**LEEANN:** I can't! Doctors did it at home! I don't know how!

**HEAD NURSE 1:** START THE IV!

**SISSY:** *(to audience)* And I turn, and I look at this patient

**LEANN:** *(to audience)* And half this soldier's face is gone!

**SISSY:** It's okay, I'm here – I'm right beside you – *(to audience)* His name is Jimmy. And he's ***wide awake***! Jimmy? You're not alone – I'm here . . . *(flatliner sound)*

**HEAD NURSE 1:** Next patient! ***Move on!***

**SISSY:** **(Pg 73)** *(to audience)* But we lose all GIs –

**LEANNE:** *(to audience)* And I am left with them alone – all the corpses stacked up like cordwood in a little tiny room with me – and then --

**SISSY:** *(to audience)* **(Pg 78)** [More] patients start coming in one after the other after the other – I've never seen so many patients in my life!

**MARTHA:** Here's a yellow sheet of paper. Make a list. Worst ones at the top –

**LEEANN:** But they're coming so fast, so fast –

**MARTHA:** Start using numbers instead --

**LEEANN:** Then someone worse comes in –

**MARTHA:** And I put his number at the top.

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**VOICE ON INTERCOM:** **(Pg 79)** ***Attention!*** Sapper attack! The ***enemy*** is penetrating our perimeter. Attention! Be alert! Be Alert!

**MARTHA:** The ***enemy*** is coming in ***here***? Oh my God! *(explosion, screams)* **(Pg 80-81)** THE WARD IS HIT! **(Pg 80-81)** Corpsman, lock the door! *(to audience) [*But there's] shrapnel flying though his head! And he falls on me! DEAD!! Chunks of flesh – blood – all over the walls

**LEEANN:** Screaming – yelling – smell of burning flesh –

**MARTHA:** My patients!

**SISSY:** ***Killed!*** In their hospital beds!

******scene******

**MARTHA:** *(to audience)* I'm heading into the operating room the fourth day? The fifth? And I see water coming out of the scrub sinks splashing on the floor – and patients lying on the floor – blood – the water mixing with the blood and running down the hall – a river! Oh God! Help me stay behind my wall!

**LEEANN:** *(to audience)* It's an 18-year-old coming into surgery – he's so young he doesn't even have hair on his face – and I'm running beside his stretcher, and he's crying – Mommy? Mommy? And I'm saying: I'm here, baby – Mommy's right here! Only I'm just 21 myself.

**SISSY:** *(to audience)* He's a blond kid from California looking just like your brother and screaming: I DON"T WANT TO DIE!

**MARTHA:** *(to audience)* **(Pg 82)** A piece of my heart goes with each of them! A PIECE OF MY HEART!

**WHITNEY:** *(to audience)* A hundred days before you leave you start filling in the short timer's calendar – marking off each day.

**MARTHA:** *(to audience)* Wanting to go – but not wanting to go –

**LEEANN:** **(Pg 83)** I walk into the hospital to say goodbye. Strangely quiet day. Suddenly the double doors burst open and two litter bearers run in, set down their litter, run out. *(looking closely at the patients)* A little Vietnamese boy and girl – both with their hands

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chopped off. Looking at us – *(she struggles with the image)* gaping, dumb, numb – I walk out the door of the hospital in silence – for the last time, Vietnam. I am going home.

*****scene*****

**ALL: (Pg 86)** *American soil!*

**LEEANN: (Pg 93-94)** *(to audience)* I end up on a bus to LA – In the depot I see people waving signs –

**PROTESTOR:** *(marching and yelling)* PEACE NOW! HEY, HEY, LBJ, HOW MANY KIDS DID YOU KILL TODAY? MAKE LOVE, NOT WAR!

**LEEANN:** My friend comes running up

**FRIEND:** Jesus! You got a dress in your bag? Jeans? Something else to wear?

**LEANN:** *(proudly)* It's my uniform! It's got all my medals on!

**FRIEND:** Go change! You're a target! For God's sake!

**LEANN:** Target?

**PROTESTOR:** *(yelling in her face, spitting)* MURDERER! BUTCHER! GO BACK TO NAM! WAR MONGER! GET OUT OF HERE!

**LEEANN:** *(to audience - confused)* So I run to the washroom, change out of my uniform, I run back. *(to Friend)* Burn it! *(throws duffle on ground).*

**FRIEND:** But your medals . . .

**LEEANN:** **** MY MEDALS! BURN IT, I SAID!!

*****scene*****

**LEEANN: (Pg 100-101)** *(to audience)* I'm out of the service. San Francisco. Intensive care. They won't let me hang a pint of blood without supervision. I was treated different in Nam. Trusted. They're putting me through an Orientation Course about CPR?! I quit!

**MARTHA: (Pg 100-101)** *(to audience)* I go back into the military. The Reserves. To teach. A chance to show my skills. *(To Leeann)* I can't stand these Reserve nurses! They played it safe during Nam. Why aren't they active? All these nurses paid for *practicing*? Why don't they do what they're practicing for. I quit!

**LEEANN:** Job to job to job –

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**MARTHA:** Looking – for the respect – the thrill – the challenge –

**LEEANN:** Homesick for the GIs of Nam.

**MARTHA:** "Adrenalin Junkies" that's us.

**LEEANN:** *(to audience)* I stop putting Nam down on my application form. I demonstrate ***against*** the war! I march! I carry signs!

**SISSY:** **(Pg 111-112)** *(to audience)* Since I came back I've watched MASH. Current. Reruns. Everything. I cry. Every time. Doesn't matter what the story is. I cry. Chopper in the sky I cry. Color khaki on the screen I cry. Sad . . . terribly sad to me – all of it . . . *(starting to tear up)*

**LEEANN:** **(Pg 114-115)** *(anger and rage mount as she speaks)* I see the hostages from Iran on TV. And this is pissing me off! ***They*** are getting into limos for this big parade with the Yellow Ribbon Welcome and what did ***they*** do? Sat around four hundred days reading coming books while ***I*** was risking my life. Getting cursed and spit at in my uniform? *(Martha grabs her, tries to calm her down; she wrenches free)* No! Don't you touch me! I could kill someone, you know that? I could kill . . . me *(breaks down into tears)* me . . . me . . . me . . .

**MARTHA:** **(Pg 116)** *(moves away, to audience)* You people! Whoever you are! Who sent me over there . . . You are hiding behind so many other people you will never be brought to justice in this world! I WANT YOUR DAY OF RECKONING TO BE AT HAND! I WANT YOU TO BURN FOREVER IN THE HELL OF VIETNAM! *(Long beat)* I want . . .

**ALL:** to never fight another war. . . **(Pg 124)** *(softly singing)* America, America . . . God shed his grace on thee, and crown thy good with brotherhood, from sea to shining sea.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

*Author: Shirley Lauro*
*ISBN: 978-0573693335*
*Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.*
*Date (Month/Year): Jan 1992*

## AWARD HISTORY

*2001 National Qualifier*
*2002 National Qualifier*
*2003 National Qualifier*
*2005 National Qualifier*
*2007 National Qualifier*
*2010 National Qualifier*
*2011 National Qualifier*
*2013 National Qualifier*
*2014 National Qualifier*
*2015 National Qualifier*
*2016 National Qualifier*
*IL State Qualifier*
*KS State Qualifier*
*OH State Qualifier*

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